opposition. They argued forcefully that I was wrong, but I just put my foot down.

I did not think of the operation (and never have) as an “arms-for-hostage” deal, because it wasn’t. Cap and George had both had experience in prior administrations. I couldn’t ignore their warning that if word about the initiative leaked out, it would be misinterpreted—but I just felt that the opportunities involved justified taking the chance. I didn’t expect the plan to fail, but if it did, I was prepared to take the heat.

Through February, we expected the hostages to be released almost on a daily basis, but they didn’t come. We pressed harder for direct talks with moderate Iranian officials, always maintaining tight secrecy over the operation because any leaks could threaten the hostages as well as the people we were dealing with in Iran. Meanwhile, we had other matters to deal with in the Middle East.

In March, the Sixth Fleet launched a new round of naval maneuvers in “Qaddafi’s lake”—the Gulf of Sidra—and we waited to see what his response would be. Commanders of our flotilla were instructed to cross what Qaddafi called his “line of death”—an imaginary boundary in the high seas more than one hundred miles off the coast of his country (and far beyond the twelve-mile limit set by international law), which Qaddafi claimed delineated Libyan territory. I ordered that, if Libya attacked our aircraft or ships, our forces were to reply in kind, but with a measured and limited response.

Two days after the maneuvers began, Qaddafi’s forces fired SAM missiles at several of our carrier-based planes (and missed) and sent several missile-firing boats within the vicinity of our fleet—an act of aggression in international waters. We responded by sinking the Libyan vessels and knocking out the radar installation that had guided the Libyan missiles. After that, our intelligence agencies went on